WORKSHEET

MEMBERSHIP SITE PLANNING

ONTRAPORT

ABOUT THIS WORKSHEET

Membership Site Planning

This worksheet is designed to familiarize you with membership sites and help you work through the thought process of planning your own site. This involves asking the tough questions about your product and your market, strategizing about your site content and how you want to deliver it, and determining the right membership levels and pricing. By the end, you'll have a plan for ensuring your membership site stands out in the market and is engaging for your audience and successful for your business.

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CHAPTER 1

THE BENEFITS OF A MEMBERSHIP SITE

Many entrepreneurs dream of being able to work from a beach in Tahiti or a yurt in Big Sur at least once in awhile. But most business owners are tethered indefinitely to their office, and the idea of leaving their business and touring the world — or even taking a weeklong holiday — seems absurd.

If only there were a way to secure an automated passive income stream ...

Enter the gated membership site.

A subscription product doesn't require anyone physically at the wheel to guarantee an income, and it requires little daily upkeep. Successful membership sites combine the right software with valuable content and a sales funnel that reliably converts leads into sales.

You may already have a successful web presence. Perhaps you're a blogger with a strong following, have an ecommerce site or are publishing podcasts or videos. Or maybe you just have a list of contacts receiving your monthly enewsletter. Regardless, adding a membership component to your web presence can help you earn more money.

Membership sites offer benefits including:

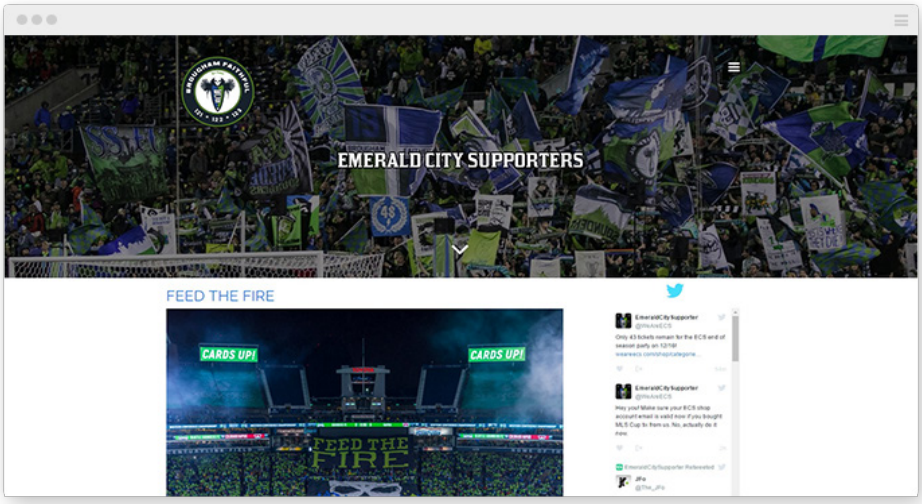
- **REACHING A BROADER AUDIENCE** Sharing your knowledge one-to-many instead of one-to-one will create stronger relationships with your existing buyers and result in more customers for you.
- **EARNING RECURRING REVENUE** Running a membership site allows you to stop trading hours for dollars and start earning a (relatively) passive, recurring cash flow.
- **A SPACE FOR USER INTERACTION** Membership sites enable members to leave comments on your pages, opening the door for interactivity through which you can foster customer relationships. You can even launch a full-blown forum site aimed at member interaction and open discussion.
- **ALL YOUR CONTENT PUBLISHED IN ONE PLACE** Quickly and easily publish your written content, audio, video and file downloads in a single, convenient place thereby giving members of your site the ability to log in and consume all your content whenever it suits them.
- **THE OPPORTUNITY TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE FOR OTHERS** A membership site gives you the ideal platform to help others gain something they want in life and avoid pain. If you're an expert or coach in a particular field or niche, membership sites provide a platform to share that knowledge with others without adding to your workload.

CHAPTER 2

TYPES OF MEMBERSHIP SITES

Some examples of successful membership sites include:

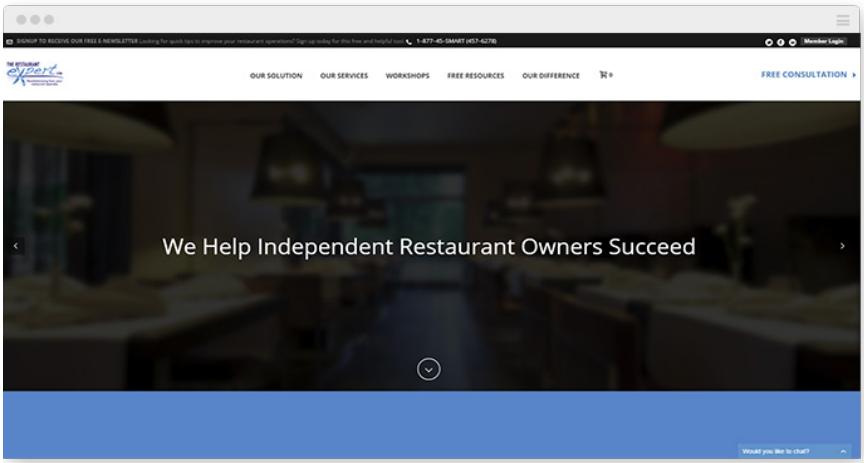
- Fan sites such as Emerald City Supporters bring fans of the Seattle Sounders soccer club together through a gated site that allows them to access members-only events, discounts on tickets, and a private ticket exchange.



- Educational sites such as GuitarTricks offer a free membership to teach people to play guitar from beginners to advanced using in-depth video lessons. If members like it, they can upgrade to a full access subscription for more content.

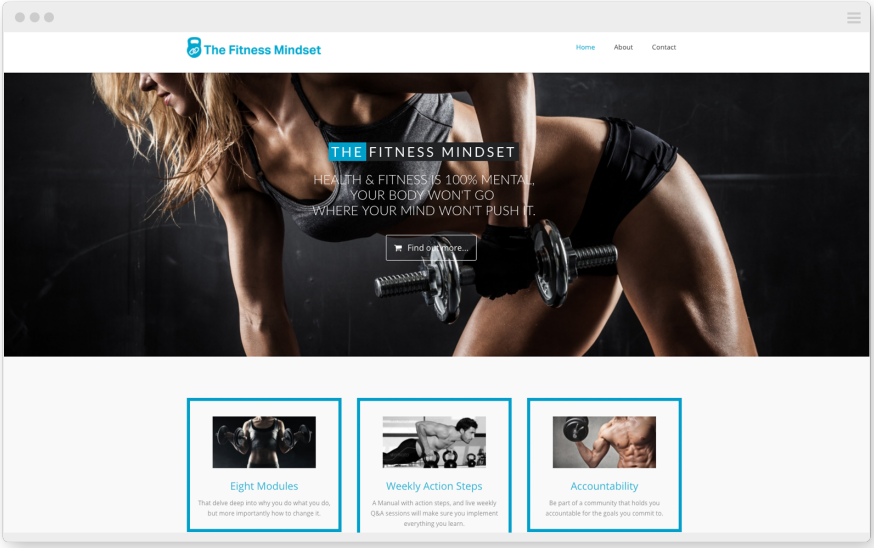
- Community forum sites such as Windy City Blogger Collective grant members a seat among a professional network of bloggers along with access to a multitude of exclusive content and invitations to blogging events.

- Business support sites such as The Restaurant Expert offer a vast amount of content and resources that assist members in running a successful, independent restaurant.



- Training sites such as Book More Brides offers monthly wedding marketing webinars with transcripts and summaries to keep members engaged.

- Coaching sites such as The Fitness Mindset offers members eight online modules and live coaching calls, monthly exercise workbooks, and access to a private Facebook community.



These are just some examples of many; the idea is that people will pay you for the right to access content that you create or curate. They pay you and, in return, you send them the credentials to log in and join your community.

CHAPTER 3

IS A MEMBERSHIP SITE RIGHT FOR ME?

It's important to determine if a membership site is right for you before you invest significant time into creating and designing one. The following questions will help you decide whether a membership site will benefit you, and your answers will guide the construction of your site. The more precise your knowledge is in each of these areas, the greater the value you'll provide to your members.

Ask Yourself the Following Questions:

Am I genuinely an expert on this topic?

- Do you know enough that you could offer real value to others looking to learn about this topic? Why would someone turn to you as opposed to any other knowledgeable source for this information? The stronger your answer, the more credibility you can build into your sales funnel.

  _____

  _____

  _____

- If you don't think of yourself as an expert, can you make a good argument for why people should come to your site for the content you're offering? Just because you are not the expert does not mean that you can't provide something of value. For example, maybe you are really well-connected and can link like-minded people, you have the resources to create the site where others can congregate, or you have great taste and can curate the best work by others in one place. What can you offer?

  _____

  _____

  _____

Am I genuinely passionate about this subject?

- It's not worth spending time on something that doesn't get you excited to get out of bed in the morning. Without passion as the driving force, the lack of authenticity in your products will shine through. If you don't love it, don't do it. What motivates you to invest your time and energy into this site? What goals are you excited about?

  _____

  _____

  _____

What am I offering? Be specific:

What do you plan to offer your members after they join the community? What will they have access to that will motivate them to renew their memberships? Check all that could apply to your business, and think about how each idea could benefit your members:

- Access to a collection of information, insights or advice
- Access to a community of like-minded individuals
- Access to discounts or special merchandise
- Access to a specific course of educational material
- Access to you or another expert
- Something else: _____

How do you plan on using these offers to benefit your members?

_____
_____
_____

Who is my target audience? Be as specific as you can.

Get to know your audience. Once you understand who you're selling to, you can use that information to find out how you can cater to them. Start out with the basics: What do you know about their lives?

- How old are they? _____
- Are they men, women or both? _____
- What are their occupations? _____
- Do they have kids? _____
- Any other important information? _____

Now that you've thought about basic demographics, you can go deeper. Answer these questions about your audience. The more detail you use, the easier it will be to connect to your members.

- What are their hopes and aspirations? _____
  _____
- How can what I offer help them reach these goal? _____
  _____
- What are their fears and frustrations? _____
  _____
- How can I help them avoid this pain?_____
  _____

Once you familiarize yourself with your audience, you'll be able to accurately answer the biggest question for creating membership content:

- What type of information is this audience looking for? _____
  _____
  _____

Is there a market for what I'm offering?

Odds are, you're not the only one trying to create resources for your target audience. Think about the market that may already exist for your product or service: What other solutions are out there? How are people in your target audience currently solving their problems? Do some research, then answer these questions for an understanding of the market you're about to enter:

- Are there other successful sites in this industry? _____
  _____
- Are there many popular blogs? _____
  _____

- Are there many YouTube videos? _____
  _____
- Search Google for keywords — what's the AdWords competition? _____
- Are there popular Facebook groups on the subject? _____
  _____
- What resources are people currently using?
  - Competitive sites
  - Books
  - Clubs
  - Trainors, coaches, tutors
  - Classes
  - Something Else: _____
    _____
- Can you beat these resources? How?_____
  _____

You know who your audience is and what the market is already offering them. Now, put yourself in their shoes and think about how they would answer these questions:

- Would I buy a book, take a class, or read a blog to solve my problem? What content would need to be included and in what format?
  _____
  _____
  _____

- What would it take to get me to choose this site in comparison to the other options available? Would it have to be faster or contain more easily achievable results? More detailed training? Expert sources? _____
  _____
  _____

  With your audience's perspective in mind, think about how you can improve your site to fit their needs:

- How would you make it easier for people to use?_____
  _____
  _____

- How would you make it more compelling or interesting?
  _____

- How would you make it more fun? Could you add gamification?
  _____
  _____

After thinking through these ideas in detail, you should have a more complete understanding of who your audience is, what they want, and how to best cater to their unique needs. But at this point, you're still playing a guessing game. To make sure you're on the right track, try asking your existing audience the questions above. See how well their answers line up to your own, and adjust your approach accordingly.

Where is the value to the member who chooses me over my competitors?

- Why should somebody give you his/her money for access? How would potential members benefit? Would it be worth their investment?
  _____
  _____

- If there are others in the market, how do you compare? Can you compete with existing companies who have the same target audience?

  _____

  _____

How am I going to establish credibility?

Your customers won't be interested in a membership if they don't trust your information or qualifications. Consider how the following strategies could build your credibility:

- Starting a blog: _____

  _____

  _____

  Go for it! _____ Maybe _____ Not for me _____

- Creating an email campaign to build relationships: _____

  _____

  _____

  _____

  Go for it! _____ Maybe _____ Not for me _____

- Offering education for free (like an ebook or free webinar): ___

  _____

  _____

  _____

  Go for it! _____ Maybe _____ Not for me _____

  Collecting testimonials from people who know and trust you:

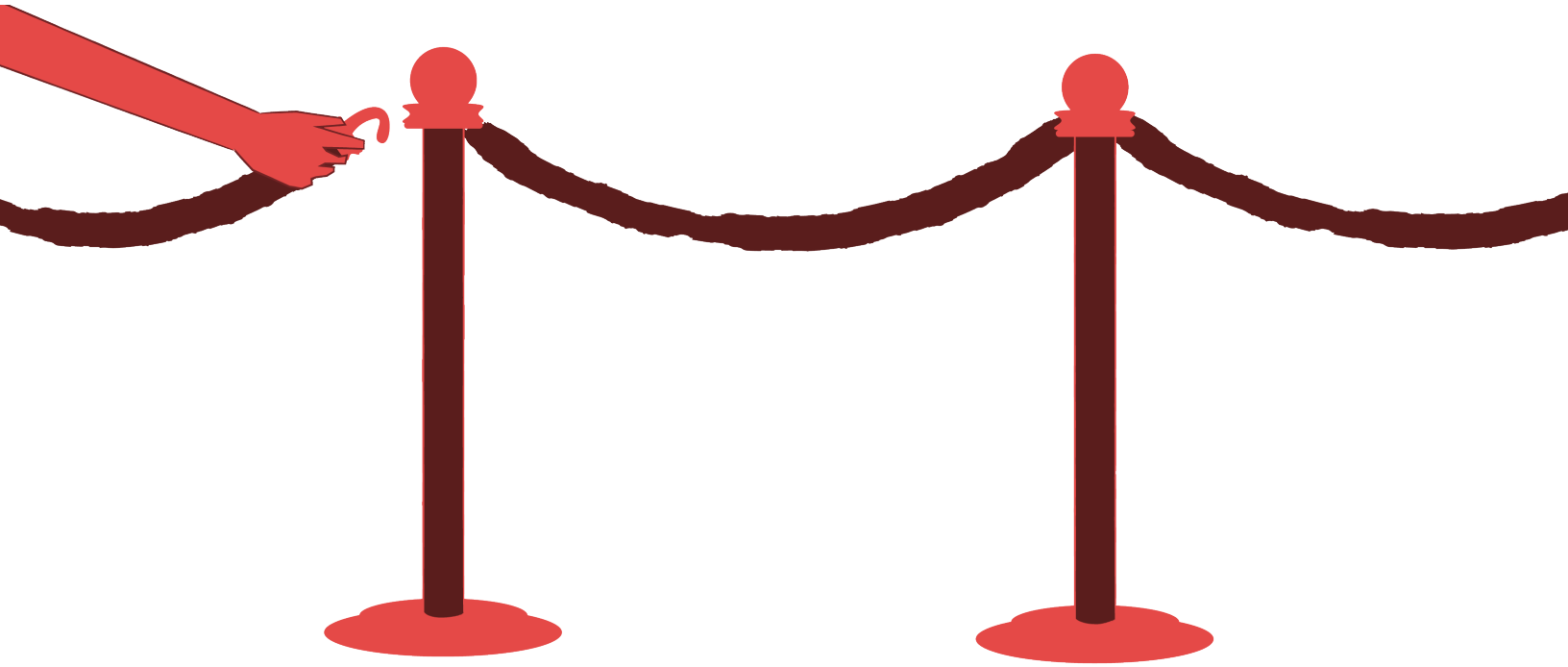
  _____

  _____

  _____

  Go for it! _____ Maybe _____ Not for me _____

Understanding your audience and market is a crucial step to creating a successful membership site. Once you have a grasp on the best ways to reach your goals, it'll be a smooth transition to applying that information to your site itself.



CHAPTER 4

STRUCTURING YOUR MEMBERSHIP PROGRAM

The preliminary steps of this process had you hovering around 30,000 feet to think broadly about what it is that you're offering and why people will pay you to access it. This next section brings you down a few thousand feet to more specifically identify how you want to present your knowledge and expertise and how you want to structure your membership program.

CONTENT TYPES

First, you'll decide what type of content you want to offer your members. Content types can be divided into several categories.

The first category of content is interactive in nature and requires you to interact more often with your members. Within this category are:

- Q & A sessions
- Live events (e.g., podcasts, videocasts or meet-ups)
- Open discussion boards

The second category includes content that is standalone; once created, this content should require little work on your part, with the exception of keeping it up-to-date. Within this category are:

- Downloadable PDFs
- Web pages
- Workbooks
- Video
- Audio recordings
- Software

In the third category, content can be standalone or it can require interaction, depending upon how you set it up. Within this category are:

- Quizzes and surveys
- Education or training lessons

How would each of these categories work with your particular content and audience? Ask yourself the following questions:

- What knowledge or expertise do I have to share with my members? What is the most effective and convenient way to share it? In other words: What type of membership site is best for my content? Why? _____
  _____
  _____
  _____

- Do I need interactive capabilities such as Q&A sessions? Why?
  _____
  _____
  _____

- What type of site would be most attractive and user-friendly for my audience?

  _____

  _____

  _____

- How busy am I? Can I afford to put in the time and work required for an interactive site, or should I use something more low-maintenance? _____

  _____

  _____

  _____

DELIVERY MODELS

Once you know the type of site that is best for your content, you can start thinking about how you want to get it to your members. Here are a few models you can choose from:

FIXED TERM: The members get access to specific content. As you add more content, you can offer it as an upsell.

TIERED: Members get access to more content based on the tier they purchase. This is the standard "pay more, get more" model. You can provide levels of access, such as Silver, Gold and Platinum; more info is given as the metals get more precious, and the price increases.

CONTENT VERTICAL: Members receive access to a bundle of content within a particular category or topic, such as all your fitness content versus all your nutrition content.

SEQUENTIAL (DRIP): Members receive access to new content every certain amount of days/weeks/months.

So which one is right for your business? Try asking yourself these questions:

- What type of information am I delivering? Is it time-relevant, like up-to-the-day stock information? Is it tutorial-based information that members will need more time to learn? Or maybe one long-term guide that could be referred to regularly? Can I divide my content into different tiers?

  _____

  _____

  _____

- If I were a member, how would I want to receive this information?

  _____

  _____

  _____

- With all that in mind: What is the best delivery model for my content?

  _____

  _____

  _____

There are still plenty of decisions to make about format even once you know you want to release content over time. Ask yourself following:

How many releases will there be?

- Will I set it up as a course with a series of lectures or as something else?

  _____

  _____

  _____

- Once they have consumed a set of content, can members select the next set of content, or is it pre-determined for them?

  _____

  _____

  _____

- How often will I release content? Daily, every other day, once a week, once a month?

  _____

  _____

  _____

Who is responsible for creating fresh content for members?

- Will I be generating the content myself? If not, who will be in charge?_____

- What systems or practices can I put in place for generating content so that I'm sure to always have enough content to create sufficient, ongoing value for my members? _____

  _____

  _____

  _____

How can my materials interact with each other?

- Do I want to offer materials that support one another? (This could include an interview with a leading expert after a blog post about related material, a checklist or guide as a PDF, a transcript of a video you offered, a PDF summary of a lesson, or case studies that exemplify what you were teaching in the lesson.) How can I make my content overlap like this? _____

  _____

  _____

  _____

How will I assess members' usage and learning?

- Will I assign "homework" to members and account for learning/retention of the material? _____
_____
_____
_____

- Will I review/critique members' assignments? If so, how, and how many of them? _____
_____
_____
_____

- Will I give quizzes and/or tests? _____
_____
_____
_____

How will I make this membership site more interactive?

- Will I include discussion forums? How can I use this to foster a sense of community for members and help them build relationships with my site? _____
_____
_____
_____

- How can I plan direct interactions with my members? Do I want to have chat office hours? A live video? An audio Q&A? How can I make this interaction increase the value of my content?
_____
_____
_____

- What milestones or rewards can I set up for my members? What are a few goals for participation, and how can members be rewarded for attaining them? Will this make my members feel recognized and appreciated?

  _____

  _____

  _____

A few additional things to consider:

- Set an end date to the membership so that people know that after a certain period of time, they should have consumed the available content. After the given time period is up, you can always move them into other programs.

  How long should the membership last before the end date?

  _____

  What other programs can follow? _____

  _____

- Think through what you want to have happen if individuals click on a membership level for which they don't have access. You can have them redirected to a page that lists the benefits of that higher membership level with an order form at the bottom for them to purchase it.
  What happens after someone's membership is over?

  _____

  _____

- We strongly recommend that you map out the path a member will take from the time he/she is exposed to your content through his/her experience with your membership site.

Use the space below to visualize a member's step-by-step experience:

CHAPTER 5

DETERMINING LEVELS OF ACCESS AND PRICING

Now it's time to figure out the best pricing model for your membership site. Consider and be informed about what others are charging for similar products, but don't be bound by it. You might create a budget solution to undercut other solutions, hoping to be the "no-brainer" option for price-conscious prospects. You might create a premium solution that's far more expensive and valuable than the rest, catering to the high-end market. Either way, it's good to know what others in your niche are charging for access to their sites.

Ask yourself the following questions to determine your pricing strategy:

1. What do my competitors charge for similar products? _____

   _____

   - Will I charge more? Why? (This could be to frame yourself as a higher-end brand or because you feel your product is better. Be sure to be able to communicate to your customers the reasons you cost more.)

     _____

     _____

     _____

     _____

   - Will I charge less? Why? (If your plan is to undercut your competitors, ensure you can still make money. If you have a less established brand, make sure you can clearly articulate why a customer should buy your product.)

     _____

     _____

     _____

2. Will I charge one set price for members or create a graduated membership structure where each higher level of membership costs progressively more? Why?

   _____

   _____

   _____

   - If I'll have multiple membership levels, how many?

     _____

- Will there be a free level to get people “in the door”?

  _____

- What will the membership levels be called? Bronze, silver and gold? Good, better, best?

  _____

3. Will it be a weekly, monthly or yearly recurring fee? Or will members just be charged a one-time access fee?

   _____

   - Is there a start-up or set-up fee? If so, how much will it be and why?

     _____

   - Will I offer a free trial? If so, how many days will the free trial last, and what will it entail?

     _____

CHAPTER 6

FINAL THOUGHTS

Membership sites are a great way to attract a niche community of customers or to get your existing customers involved on a deeper level. They require a lot of work and planning to get started, plus on-going upkeep to engage with members and make sure your content is current. But in the long run, it's well worth your time. Your members will be more engaged with each other and your business; you'll have opportunities to build your brand, and you'll be making lots of passive income. Armed with this knowledge, use a membership site to engage with as many people as you can draw into your funnel.

ONTRAPORT

ONTRAPORT's mission is to support entrepreneurs in delivering their value to the world by removing the burden of technology. We deliver on that mission by creating software, offering services, and educating the entrepreneurial community.

For over a decade, we have made a difference for thousands of businesses, their communities, and our own staff, which is why we've received countless awards for innovation, revenue growth and company culture.

Our flagship marketing automation product is a subscription software that provides our customers with all the tools they need to start and grow their businesses through the advantage of an all-in-one platform. In addition, we offer a large collection of free resources, courses and educational products that support entrepreneurs at all stages throughout their journey.

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